



Go Wirefree

Wireless solutions are beginning to pick up in India. Here is a lowdown on what options exist in order to go wirefree

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Wireless devices are redefining the word “mobility.” Laptops were the forerunners of the mobility theme, and wireless devices are taking it to the next level. The long-cherished dream of pervasive computing now feels closer to home.

While wireless devices were around long enough, it was only after the introduction of Intel's Centrino platform that it caught on to the imagination of mainstream industry bigwigs.

Intel's Centrino is a platform comprising of a CPU, a chipset and a wireless device, all bundled together in a nifty laptop. But there is more to the Centrino than just a laptop—it is a complete platform created from the ground up for mobile computing.

The wireless entity in this platform enables you to access your data anywhere and

anytime, provided the right infrastructure is there. “Infrastructure” here denotes specific locations where you can connect wirelessly to a device connected to the Internet.

Such locations are called hotspots, and the device to which you connect are the access points. This complete eco-system, when ready, allows you to access your mails, data etc. from almost any place such as airports, bus stops, restaurants, your bed etc—and that, without messy wire connections.

On the software end, these devices automatically recognise each other's presence, and do the necessary settings required for smooth connection.

For setting up a wireless environment, access points, or APs as they are called, and PCMCIA / PCI cards are the most basic devices required. Depending upon the standards they employ, such devices are categorised as 802.11a, 802.11b and 802.11g.

Introduction To The 802.11 Standards

In 1997, the Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (IEEE) created the first WLAN (wireless LAN) standard. They called it 802.11, after the name of the group that oversaw its development. Unfortunately, 802.11 supported a maximum bandwidth of only 2 Mbps, which was too slow for most applications.

